
BUT YOU UNDERSTAND, NEVER ANJA AND I WERE SEPARATED!
NO?!
NO! THE WAR PUT US APART. BUT ALWAYS, BEFORE AND AFTER, WE WERE TOGETHER.
NOT SO LIKE MALA, WHAT GRABS OUT MY MONEY!-
AUSCHWITZ, POP. TELL ME ABOUT AUSCHWITZ.
AUSCHWITZ WAS IN A TOWN CALLED OSWIECIM. BEFORE THE WAR I CAME OFTEN HERE TO SELL MY TEXTILES.
...AND NOW, I CAME AGAIN.
WE CAME TO A BIG HALL AND THEY SHOUTED ON US.
GET UNDRESSED! LEAVE YOUR VALUABLES! LINE UP! SCHNELL!
I WAS, AT THAT TIME, STILL WITH MY FRIEND MANDELBAUM.
THEY TOOK FROM US OUR PAPERS, OUR CLOTHES AND OUR HAIR..
(PSST- WH-WHAT'S GOING TO HAPPEN TO US?)
(DON'T WORRY..)
WE WERE COLD, AND WE WERE AFRAID.
(IF THEY BROUGHT YOU HERE, THEY'LL PUT YOU TO WORK-THEY'RE NOT READY TO KILL YOU YET.)
(WHAT ABOUT OUR WIVES AND OUR-)
SHUT UP, YIDS! TO THE BATH HOUSE. QUICK!

EVERYWHERE WE HAD TO RUN – SO LIKE *JOGGERS* – AND THEY RAN US TO THE SAUNA ...



IN THE SNOW THEY THREW TO US PRISONERS CLOTHINGS.

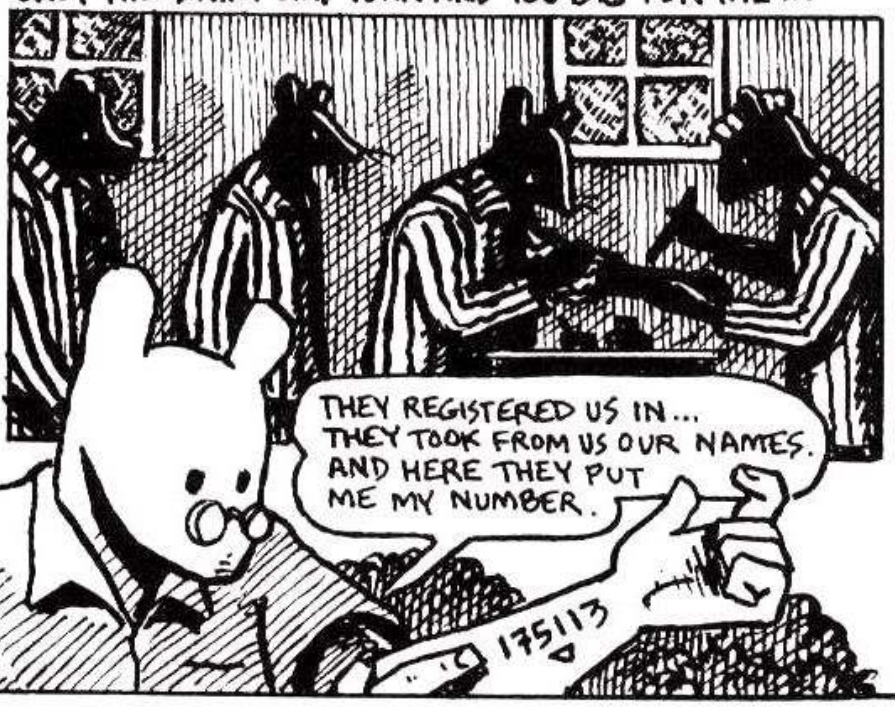


ONE GUY TRIED TO EXCHANGE.

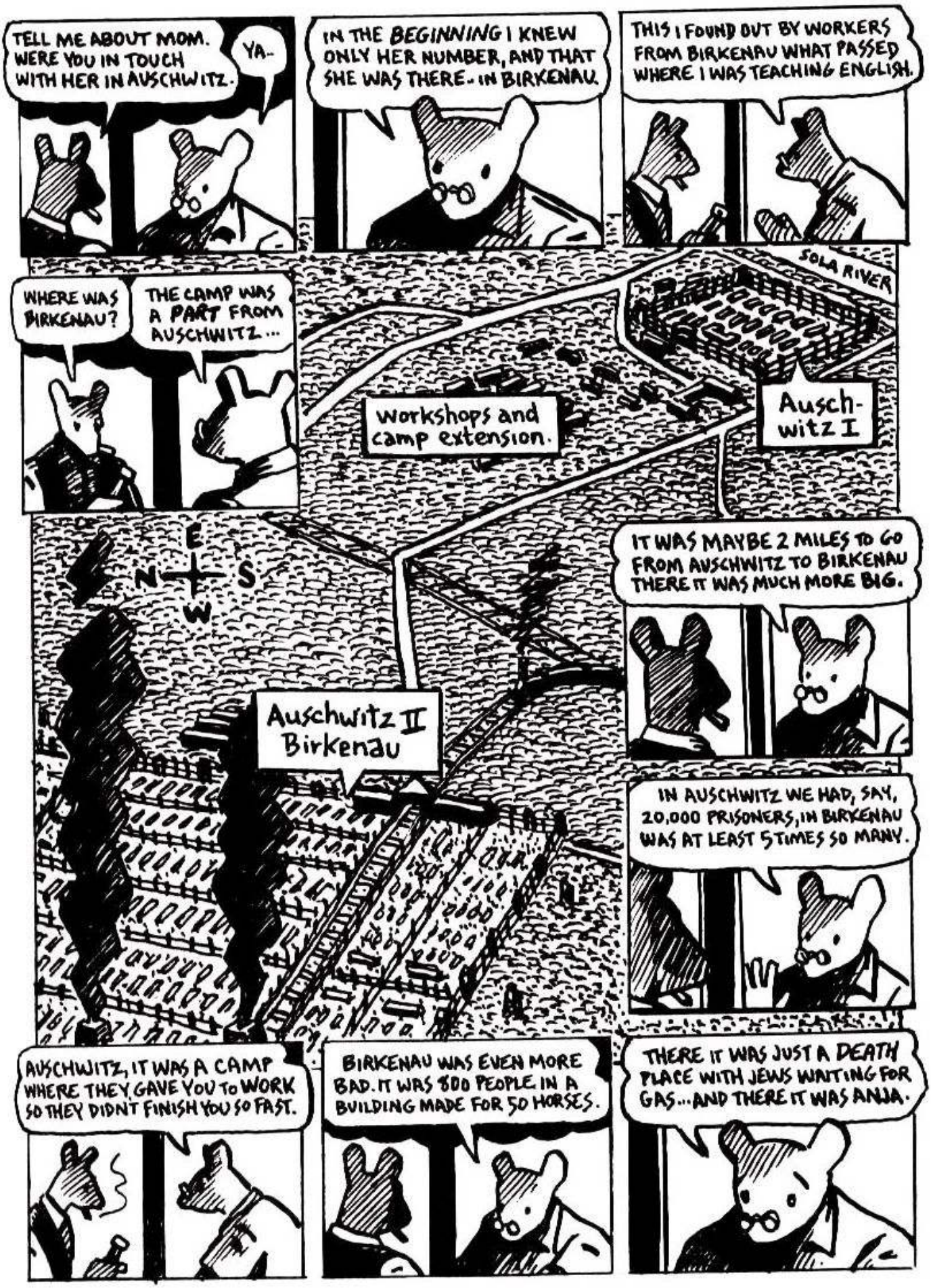




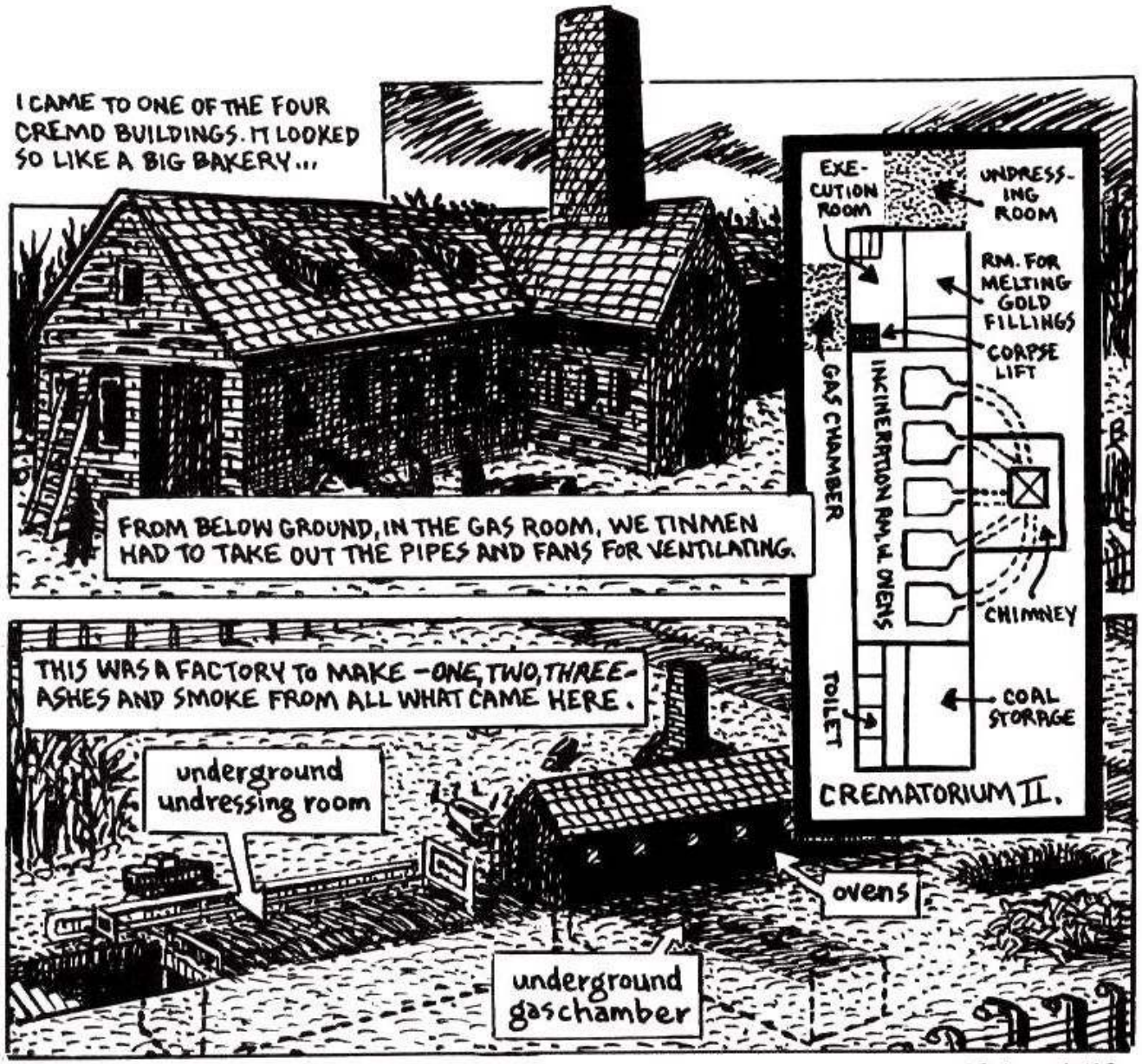
I WAS A LUCKY ONE. EVERYTHING FITTED ME A LITTLE. ONLY THE SHIRT WAS TORN AND TOO BIG FOR ME ...




ALL AROUND WAS A SMELL SO TERRIBLE, I CAN'T EXPLAIN... SWEETISH... SO LIKE RUBBER BURNING. AND FAT.
UNCLE! UNCLE!
WHEN WE CAME INSIDE THE GATES SOMEONE RAN TO US FROM FAR AWAY.
HERE WAS ABRAHAM — MANDELBAUM'S NEPHEW!
SO, UNCLE... YOU'VE ENDED UP HERE TOO.
YOU TOLD US TO COME!
YOU WROTE US ABOUT HOW HAPPY YOU ARE IN HUNGARY - THAT WE SHOULD JOIN YOU RIGHT AWAY! WELL... HERE WE ARE.
HUN-GARY. HAH!
THE POLES WHO ARRANGED OUR "ESCAPE" UNDERSTOOD YIDDISH. SO THEY KNEW YOU WERE WAITING TO HEAR IF I WAS SAFE.
IN BIELSKO THE POLES DICTATED THAT LETTER WHILE THE GESTAPO HELD A PISTOL UP TO MY HEAD.
WHAT COULD I DO? THEY'D HAVE SHOT ME THEN AND THERE.
WELL... SO HERE'S OUR HUNGARY...
AND THERE'S ONLY ONE WAY OUT OF HERE FOR ALL OF US ... THROUGH THOSE CHIMNEYS.
ABRAHAM I DIDN'T SEE AGAIN... I THINK HE CAME OUT THE CHIMNEY.
BUT I SAW AGAIN ONCE THE POLES WHO BETRAYED US.
THE GERMANS DIDN'T NEED THEM. SO THEY FINISHED ALSO IN AUSCHWITZ.

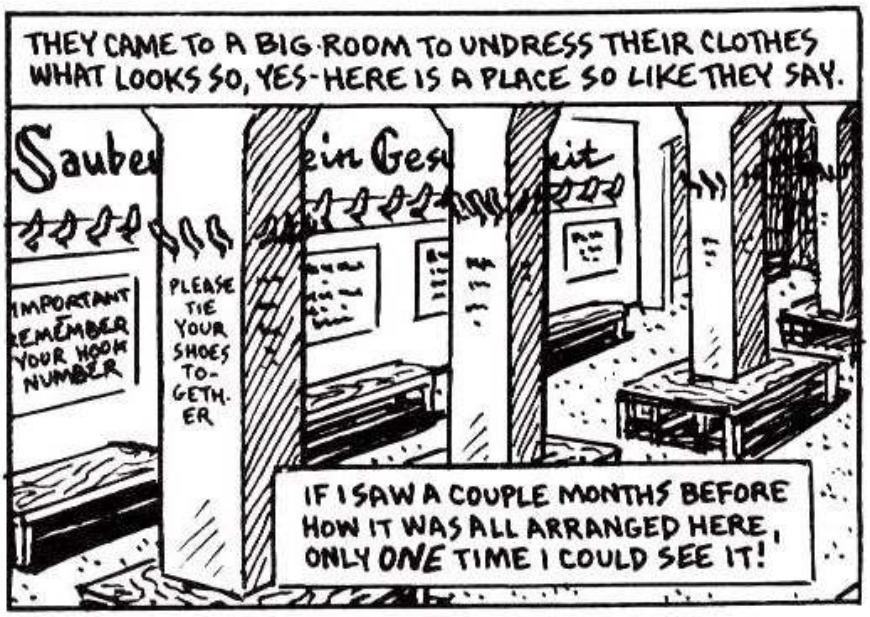

TELL ME ABOUT MOM. WERE YOU IN TOUCH WITH HER IN AUSCHWITZ.
YA-
IN THE BEGINNING I KNEW ONLY HER NUMBER, AND THAT SHE WAS THERE - IN BIRKENAU.
THIS I FOUND OUT BY WORKERS FROM BIRKENAU WHAT PASSED WHERE I WAS TEACHING ENGLISH.
SOLA RIVER
WHERE WAS BIRKENAU?
THE CAMP WAS A PART FROM AUSCHWITZ...
workshops and camp extension.
Ausch-witz I
N
E
S
W
Auschwitz II Birkenau
IT WAS MAYBE 2 MILES TO GO FROM AUSCHWITZ TO BIRKENAU THERE IT WAS MUCH MORE BIG.
IN AUSCHWITZ WE HAD, SAY, 20,000 PRISONERS, IN BIRKENAU WAS AT LEAST 5 TIMES SO MANY.
AUSCHWITZ, IT WAS A CAMP WHERE THEY GAVE YOU TO WORK SO THEY DIDN'T FINISH YOU SO FAST.
BIRKENAU WAS EVEN MORE BAD. IT WAS 800 PEOPLE IN A BUILDING MADE FOR 50 HORSES.
THERE IT WAS JUST A DEATH PLACE WITH JEWS WAITING FOR GAS... AND THERE IT WAS ANJA.


COME...IT'S TIME NOW WE'LL HURRY FOR LUNCH HOME TO THE BUNGALOW.
SO YOU WERE ACTUALLY IN TOUCH WITH ANJA IN BIRKENAU?
YAH. FROM MANCIE I HAD A REAL CONTACT WITH MOTHER, UNTIL LATER I COULD BRING ANJA TO-
WAIT! WHO'S MANCIE?
SHE WAS A HUNGARIAN, MANCIE, WHO WORKED SOMETIMES THERE. BEAUTIFUL. A TALL BLONDE GIRL. AND CLEVER.
REST BEHIND THAT STACK OF WOOD. I'LL WARN YOU IF A GUARD COMES CLOSE.
SHE HAD A LOVER, I HEARD LATER AN S.S. MAN. HE GOT FOR HER A GOOD POSITION OVER 10 OR 12 OTHER GIRLS FROM BIRKENAU.
(PSST, MISS-UP HERE! I SEE HOW KIND YOU ARE. HELP ME. PLEASE!)
HUH? (WHAT DO YOU WANT?)
(NOTHING FOR ME, BUT I'M AFRAID FOR MY WIFE IN BIRKENAU. CAN YOU FIND OUT IF SHE'S STILL ALIVE?)
I TOLD TO HER ANJA'S NAME AND NUMBER.
(I'VE SAVED SOME FOOD. I CAN PAY FOR YOUR HELP.)
(KEEP YOUR FOOD. WE'LL BE WORKING HERE AGAIN IN A FEW DAYS. I'LL SEE WHAT I CAN FIND OUT.)
EACH DAY I LOOKED. FOUR DAYS AFTER, I SAW HER.
I MET A WOMAN NAMED ANJA FROM SOSNOWIEC. SHE'S VERY FRAIL...
!
SHE SPOKE OVER TO ONE OF HER WORKERS; I SPOKE ONLY TO MY TIN SO NOBODY WILL NOTICE.
SOMEONE TOLD HER THAT HER HUSBAND IS STILL ALIVE AND SHE STARTED SOBBING WITH JOY.
I HEARD THIS, AND I STARTED ALSO CRYING A LITTLE. AND MANCIE, SHE TOO STARTED CRYING.



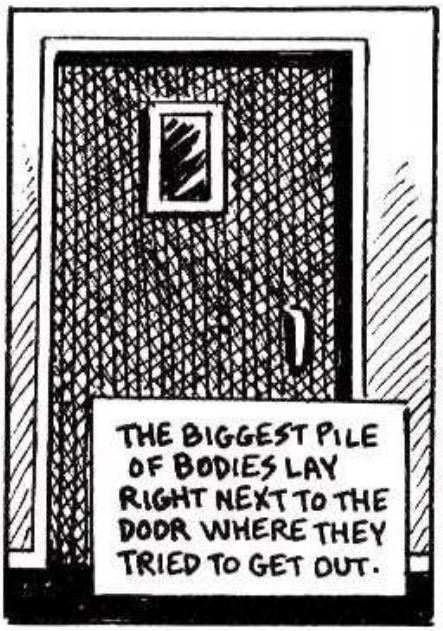
SPECIAL PRISONERS WORKED HERE SEPARATE. THEY GOT BETTER BREAD, BUT EACH FEW MONTHS THEY ALSO WERE SENT UP THE CHIMNEY. ONE FROM THEM SHOWED ME EVERYTHING HOW IT WAS.





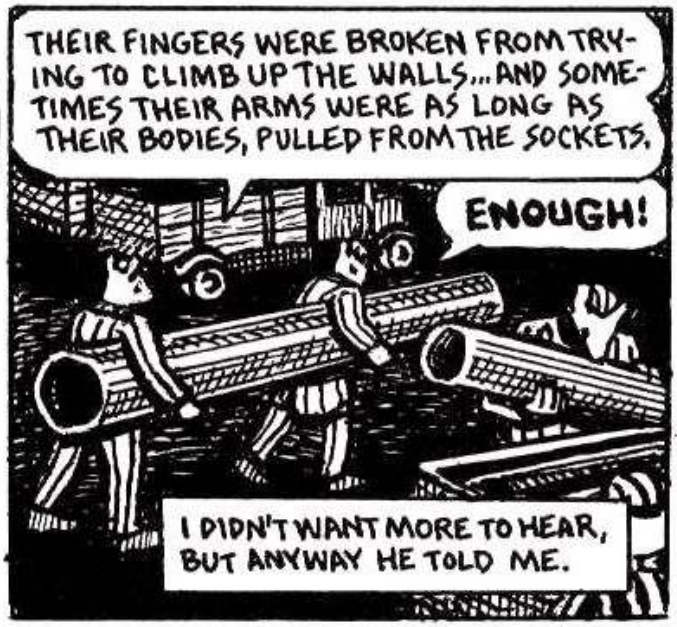
AND EVERYBODY CROWDED INSIDE INTO THE SHOWER ROOM, THE DOOR CLOSED HERMETIC, AND THE LIGHTS TURNED DARK.





THIS GUY WHO WORKED THERE, HE TOLD ME...





THEY PULLED THE BODIES WITH AN ELEVATOR UP TO THE OVENS— MANY OVENS — AND TO EACH ONE THEY BURNED 2 OR 3 AT A TIME.



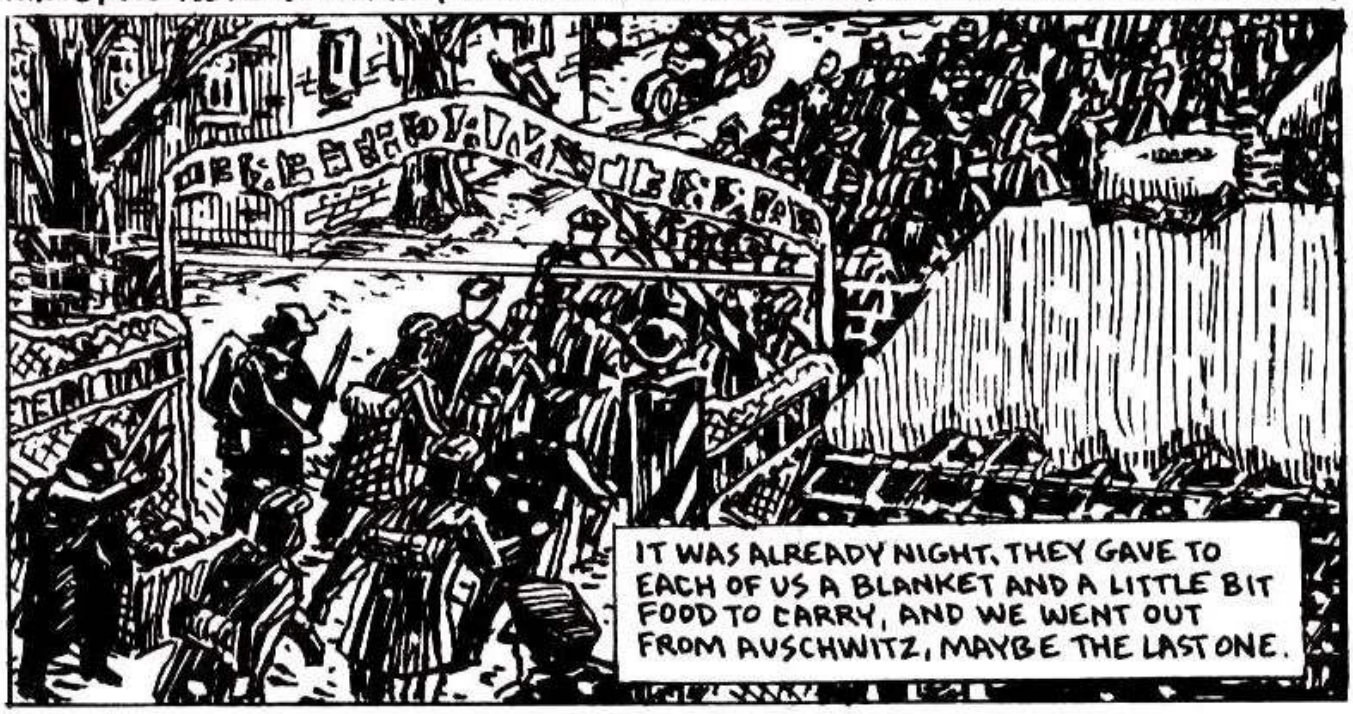


THEN THIS GUY FROM THE OFFICE RAN IN...





FINALLY THEY ***DIDN'T*** BOMB, BUT THIS WE COULDN'T KNOW. WE LEFT BEHIND *EVERY-THING*, WE WERE SO AFRAID, EVEN THE CIVILIAN CLOTHES WE ORGANIZED. AND RAN OUT!



ONE OF THE BOYS WHAT WE WERE IN THE ATTIC TOGETHER, TALKED OVER TO THE GUARD..





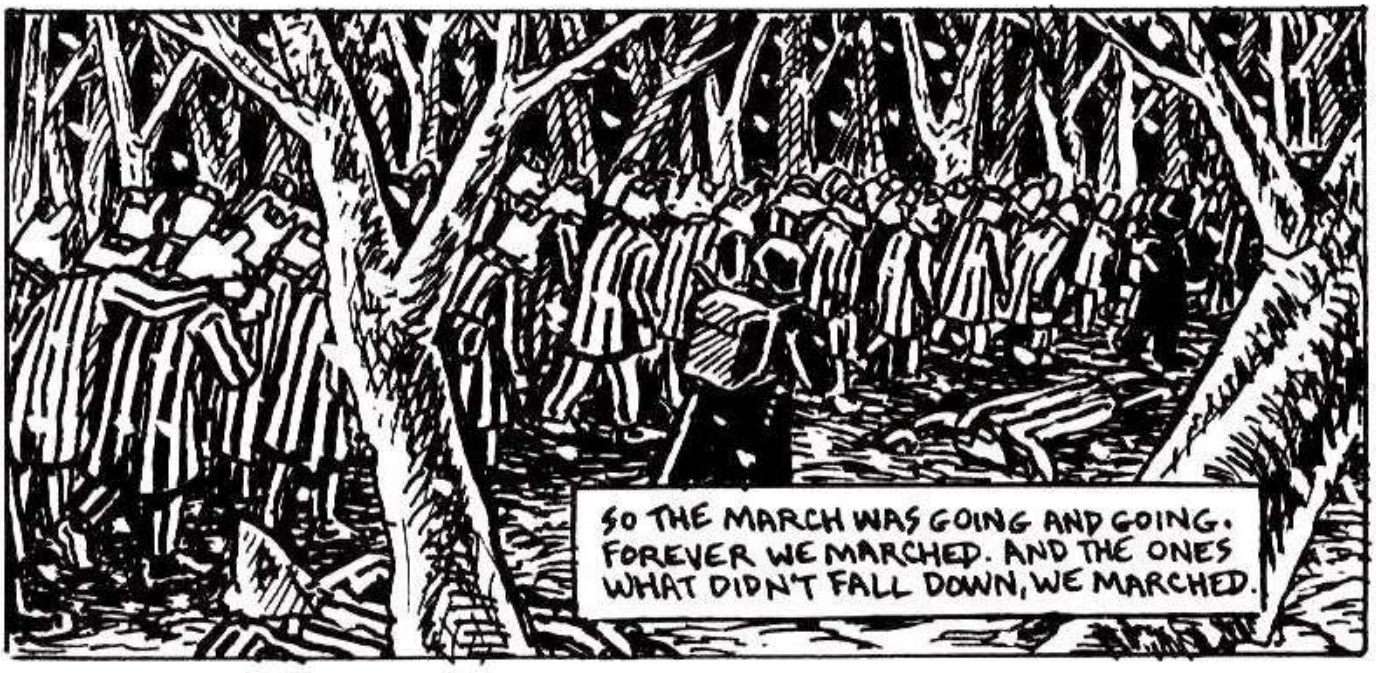


ALL DAY LONG THEY WERE ARRANGING...



AT NIGHT WAS A COMMOTION. 8 OR 9 RAN OFF..





IN THE MORNING THEY CHASED US TO MARCH AGAIN OUT, WHO KNOWS WHERE...



IT WAS SUCH A TRAIN FOR HORSES, FOR COWS.



THEY PUSHED UNTIL IT WAS NO ROOM LEFT.









BUT AFTER A FEW WEEKS I GOT TOO SICK EVEN TO EAT...

TYPHUS!



I GOT VERY HOT FEVER AND I COULDN'T SLEEP. TYPHUS!

EVERY NIGHT PEOPLE DIED OF THIS.



AT NIGHT I HAD TO GO TO THE TOILET DOWN. IT WAS ALWAYS FULL, THE WHOLE CORRIDOR, WITH THE DEAD PEOPLE PILED THERE. YOU COULDN'T GO THROUGH...



YOU HAD TO GO ON THEIR HEADS, AND THIS WAS TERRIBLE, BECAUSE IT WAS SO SLIPPERY, THE SKIN, YOU THOUGHT YOU ARE FALLING. AND THIS WAS EVERY NIGHT.



SO NOW I HAD TYPHUS, AND I HAD TO GO TO THE TOILET DOWN, AND I SAID, "NOW IT'S MY TIME. NOW I WILL BE LAYING LIKE THIS ONES AND SOMEBODY WILL STEP ON ME!"


EVERYBODY OUT! LINE UP IN FIVES!
HERE WAS THE END OF OUR RIDE.
WE HAD FROM HERE TO GO BY FOOT TO THE FRONTIER...
AND I SAW, IT'S NOT EVERYWHERE, MY HELL. IT'S STILL LIFE THINGS GOING ON.


WE MARCH. WE STOP. FOR HOURS WE STOOD.
(WHAT'S GOING ON?)
(THEY'RE TAKING US BACK TO DACHAU!)
(NO, NO. THE AMERICANS ARE COMING.)


IT WAS COMMOTIONS AND RUMORS. THEN SHOUTS:
THE WAR IS OVER!
IT WAS OVER.


MARCH BACK TO THE TRACKS! SCHNELL!


THEY DIDN'T LEAVE US GO, BUT PUT US TO A FREIGHT TRAIN.
THE AMERICANS WILL BE IN THE NEXT TOWN. THEY CAN HAVE YOU.
ON THIS TRAIN NO GUARDS CAME. SO REALLY WE SAW, IT IS OVER NOW.


REMEMBER THE GELBERS? THEY OWNED THE BIG BAKERY IN SOSNOWIEC...
"ONE OF THE SONS SURVIVED AND CAME BACK HOME...
WHAT DO YOU WANT?
THIS IS MY FAMILY'S HOUSE. I'M GELBER!
WE THOUGHT HITLER FINISHED YOU OFF!
GO AWAY, JEW! THIS IS OUR BAKERY NOW!
SLAM!
"HE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT TO DO. HE SPENT THE NIGHT IN THE SHED BEHIND HIS HOUSE...
"THE POLES WENT IN. THEY BEAT HIM AND HANGED HIM.
"...FOR THIS HE SURVIVED."
HIS BROTHER CAME FROM THE CAMPS A DAY LATER, AND ONLY STAYED LONG ENOUGH TO BURY HIM...
STOP IT!..I DON'T WANT TO HEAR ANY MORE!
JUST TELL ME. DID YOU HEAR ANYTHING ABOUT ANJA?
I SAW HER! SHE DIDN'T TRY TO GET HER PROPERTY BACK. THE POLES LEAVE HER ALONE.

ANJA WENT A FEW TIMES EACH DAY OVER TO THE JEWISH ORGANIZATION...

BUT NO SIGN CAME OF ME.

SO SHE SAT HOME EVEN MORE DEPRESSED, UNTIL...

KNOCK KNOCK

ANJA! GUESS WHAT! A LETTER FROM YOUR HUSBAND JUST CAME!

HE'S IN GERMANY... HE'S HAD TYPHUS!

IT'S JUST LIKE THE GYPSY SAID.

AND HERE'S A PICTURE OF HIM! MY GOD-VLADEK IS REALLY ALIVE!



I PASSED ONCE A PHOTO PLACE WHAT HAD A CAMP UNIFORM - A NEW AND CLEAN ONE - TO MAKE SOUVENIR PHOTOS..

ANJA KEPT THIS PICTURE ALWAYS. I HAVE IT STILL NOW IN MY DESK!

HUH? WHERE DO YOU GO?

I NEED THAT PHOTO IN MY BOOK!


WHEN I CAME FINALLY TO SOSNOWIEC, I HAVE SEEN VERY LITTLE JEWS AROUND.
BUT I FOUND OUT WHERE IS THE JEWISH ORGANIZATION.
THERE IT WAS PEOPLE WHAT KNEW ME.
LOOK WHO'S HERE! SOMEBODY FIND ANJA AND BRING HER RIGHT AWAY!
AND SOMEBODY FOUND HER...
GASP.
V-VLADEK!
IT WAS SUCH A MOMENT THAT EVERYBODY AROUND WAS CRYING TOGETHER WITH US.
ANJA, ANJA. MY ANJA!
MORE I DON'T NEED TO TELL YOU. WE WERE BOTH VERY HAPPY, AND LIVED HAPPY. HAPPY EVER AFTER.
SO... LET'S STOP, PLEASE, YOUR TAPE RECORDER...
I'M TIRED FROM TALKING, RICHIEU, AND IT'S ENOUGH STORIES FOR NOW...
SPIEGELMAN
VLADEK
Oct. 11, 1906
Aug 18, 1982
ANJA
Mar. 15, 1912
Aug 21, 1968
— art spiegelman — 1978-1991